

Clausal doubling produces phantom islands

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Abstract

Clausal doubling in Spanish seemingly displays “island effects”, i.e., the construction is unacceptable if the doubled clause is located within a syntactic island. In this paper, we argue that these restrictions are cases of *phantom islands*, that is, not the result of true syntactic island violations, but rather a byproduct of the information structure of the doubling pattern. We maintain that these effects arise from the dislocated clause being a contrastive topic. Concretely, we claim that in these cases, the sentence fails to address the immediate question under discussion presupposed by its contrastive topics. We show that this approach also accounts for the distribution of clausal doubling in embedding contexts.

Keywords— phantom islands, clausal doubling, contrastive topics, movement, Spanish

1 Introduction

Languages exhibit diverse patterns in which a verbal constituent is doubled in the left periphery of the sentence. We will use the term *predicate doubling* to encompass them. The following examples illustrate the phenomenon. As can be seen, the verb in each sentence appears both in a dislocated position and within the clause.

- (1) Red-n red ikh mame-loshn.
speak-INF speak.1SG I mama-language
‘As for speaking, I speak Yiddish.’

Yiddish (Bleaman 2021)

- (2) Sí-(é) na Kofi á-sí dán.
build-NMLZ FOC Kofi PRF-build house
‘Kofi has BUILT a house.’

Asante Twi (Hein 2016)

- (3) Leer, Juan ha leído un libro.
read-INF Juan has read a book
‘As for reading, Juan has read a book.’

Spanish (Vicente 2009)

The doubled verbs typically surface with distinct forms in predicate doubling constructions; in these examples, the sentence-initial verb is non-finite. Despite this morphological contrast, the

standard assumption in the literature is that both verbs are transformationally related. That is, the leftmost verb moved to its position from within the clause; the rightmost verb signals the position from which movement took place. In terms of the *copy theory of movement* (e.g. Nunes 2004), both elements are overt links in the same chain C (see Cho & Nishiyama 2000, Abels 2001, Nunes 2004, Kobele 2006, Landau 2006, Trinh 2009, Vicente 2007, 2009, Hein 2016, Bleaman 2021, among others). This line of analysis is schematized in (4).

$$(4) \quad [\text{CP } V_i \dots [\text{CLAUSE } \dots V_i \dots]]$$

$C = \{V_i, V_i\}$

This approach is supported by the observation that predicate doubling constructions are island-sensitive, i.e., if the rightmost verb appears within an island, the pattern becomes unacceptable. The following examples corroborate this trend with adjunct islands.

- (5) * Veys-n vel ikh im freg-n nokh dem vi er veys-t dem enter.
 know-INF will I him.ACC ask-INF after that as he know-3SG the answer.
 ‘As for knowing, I will ask him after he knows the answer.’
 Yiddish (Bleaman 2021)
- (6) * Sí-(é) na Kofi nó m nsúo efirise ɔ-a-si dan.
 build-NMLZ FOC Kofi drink water because 3SG-PRF-build house
 ‘Kofi drinks water because he has BUILT a house.’
 Asante Twi (Hein 2016)
- (7) * Comprar, he ido al cine después de comprar un libro.
 buy-INF have gone to cinema after of buy-INF a book
 ‘As for buying, I’ve gone to the movies after buying a book.’
 Spanish (Vicente 2009)

The theoretical argument stemming from these contrasts is straightforward: since islands impose a restriction on syntactic movement, the ungrammaticality of (5), (6) and (7) must be due to movement of the verb from within the adjunct. This line of reasoning is ubiquitous in syntactic theorizing: sensitivity to islands is considered a diagnosis for movement.

In this context, Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022) advance an analysis for predicate doubling in Spanish according to which both occurrences of the verb are independently generated, i.e., the leftmost verb is externally merged in the left periphery. These authors demonstrate that (i) there is no independent evidence in Spanish for the type of movement depicted in (4), and (ii) the island-sensitivity of the construction can be fully addressed by appealing to properties of information structure. They propose that the dislocated verbal projection is a *contrastive topic*. Building on Büring (2003), they maintain that a sentence containing a contrastive topic must be congruent (in the sense of Rooth 1992 and Roberts 1996) with a question about the content of the contrastive topic. Thus, an example like (3) is acceptable because this condition is met, e.g., (8a), while (7) is unacceptable because the non-dislocated material in the sentence cannot address a question about its contrastive topic, e.g., (8b).

- (8) a. $\llbracket \text{What did Juan read?} \rrbracket \subseteq \llbracket \text{Juan has read [a book]}_F \rrbracket^f$
 b. $\llbracket \text{What did I buy?} \rrbracket \not\subseteq \llbracket \text{I’ve gone to the movies after buying [a book]}_F \rrbracket^f$

This account not only explains the contrast between (3) and (7), but shows that island effects can be, in a sense, illusory: a construction might seem to be “island-sensitive” even without requiring true syntactic extraction from an island domain. Verdecchia (2023) refers to these scenarios as *phantom islands*.

In this paper, we discuss another doubling construction in Spanish that introduces phantom islands, i.e., it displays “island effects” without resorting to syntactic movement. The phenomenon involves the repetition of a whole finite clause in the left periphery. Following the designation in Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2023), we dub this pattern *clausal doubling*.

- (9) a. Que Eliana trabajó, Eliana trabajó.
 that Eliana worked.3SG Eliana worked.3SG
 ‘As for Eliana working, Eliana DID work.’
 b. Que leyó el libro, leyó el libro.
 that read.3SG the book read.3SG the book
 ‘As for her/him reading the book, she/he DID read the book.’

In what follows, we will dismiss a movement-based analysis for the data in (9), i.e., we will show that the duplicated clauses in these examples are not syntactic copies. Nevertheless, we will see that clausal doubling constructions exhibit restrictions parallel to those exemplified in (5), (6) and (7), i.e., the pattern is seemingly island-sensitive. Following and adapting the analysis for predicate doubling in Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022), we maintain that the island-like constraints attested with clausal doubling emerge from requirements of information structure, much in the same way as it was depicted in (8b), and that no (narrow) syntactic principle is involved. Overall, our goal is to provide further evidence against the extended assumption that island effects are a reliable diagnosis for movement.

The structure of the paper is as follows. In Section 2, we demonstrate that clausal doubling does not involve movement, i.e., CLAUSE 1 and CLAUSE 2 are not copies pertaining to the same chain. This lead us to conclude that the purported “island effects” attested in this construction are not due to the violation of locality constraints. In the following sections, we present our account. To begin with, in Section 3 we describe the information structure of the doubling pattern, showing that the dislocated phrase functions as a contrastive topic in Büring’s (2003) sense. Based on this characterization, in Section 4 we derive the seemingly island-like restrictions as a byproduct of a mismatch in the information structure of the sentence. Finally, in Section 5 we include some concluding remarks.

2 “Island effects” without movement

We will start our discussion of clausal doubling (Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia 2023) by introducing some convenient terminology. As its name indicates, the construction involves two synonymous clauses within a single sentence. In order to distinguish them, we will refer to the dislocated and non-dislocated clauses as CLAUSE 1 and CLAUSE 2, respectively. With no exception, CLAUSE 1 and CLAUSE 2 always express the same proposition.

- (10) $\underbrace{\text{Que Eliana trabajó}}_{\text{CLAUSE 1}}, \underbrace{\text{Eliana trabajó}}_{\text{CLAUSE 2}}$ cf. (9a)

CLAUSE 1 is in all cases an embedded declarative sentence appearing in a dislocated position. As such, it is always headed by the complementizer *que* ‘that’. In the examples in (9), CLAUSE 2 corresponds to the matrix domain and, therefore, it is not headed by any complementizers.

Clausal doubling is also possible when CLAUSE 2 is selected by a matrix predicate: as the sentences in (11) show, the rightmost duplicate may function as a complement clause. In this context, CLAUSE 2 must always be headed by a complementizer. However, this element is not always required to be the complementizer *que* ‘that’: it can also be the interrogative complementizer *si* ‘whether’ if this is required by the embedding predicate, e.g., (11c).

- (11) a. Que trabajó, supongo que trabajó.
 that worked.3SG guess.1SG that worked.3SG
 ‘As for her/him working, I guess that she/he DID work.’
 b. Que llueva, no creo que llueva.
 that rains.3SG not believe.1SG that rains.3SG
 ‘As for it raining, I don’t think it will rain.’
 c. Que va a llegar temprano, no sé si va a llegar temprano.
 that go.3SG to arrive early, not know.1SG whether go.3SG to arrive early
 ‘As for her/him arriving early, I don’t know whether she/he will arrive early.’

As mentioned earlier, clausal doubling appears to be island-sensitive. That is, the construction is unacceptable if *CLAUSE 2* is located within a syntactic island. The examples in (12) illustrate this with an adjunct, e.g., (12a), a relative clause, e.g., (12b), and a preverbal¹ subject, e.g., (12c).

- (12) a. *Que leyó el libro, Juan se durmió después de que lo leyó.
 that read.3SG the book Juan SE slept.3SG after of that it read.3SG
 ‘As for him reading the book, Juan fell asleep after he DID read it.’
 b. *Que leyó el libro, vi a la mujer que lo leyó.
 that read.3SG the book saw.1SG DOM the woman that it read.3SG
 ‘As for reading the book, I saw the woman who DID read it.’
 c. *Que leyó el libro, que hayas dicho que lo leyó me sorprendió.
 that read.3SG the book that had.2SG said that it read.3SG me surprised.3SG
 ‘As for her reading the book, that you had said that she DID read it surprised me.’

So far, the situation of clausal doubling seems to be parallel to that of predicate doubling as discussed regarding the examples in (1) to (7): since the construction is sensitive to islands, one could make the case that its derivation must involve syntactic movement. In fact, following the same logic as with predicate doubling, we could use this argument to posit an analysis of clausal doubling in which *CLAUSE 1* and *CLAUSE 2* are overt members of the same movement chain. That is, perhaps *CLAUSE 1* occupies a position in the left periphery of the sentence because it moved there; *CLAUSE 2* would signal the position from which *CLAUSE 1* moved. The basic idea is sketched in (13).

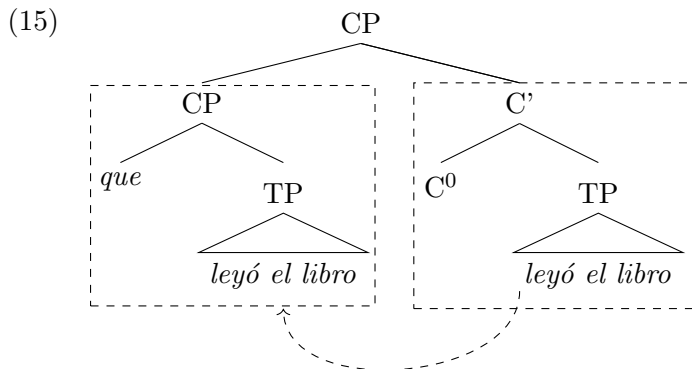
- (13) [XP *CLAUSE 1*_i ... [YP ... *CLAUSE 2*_i ...]] C = {*CLAUSE 1*, *CLAUSE 2*}
- ↑

While this type of account is, at least in principle, tenable for predicate doubling, it does not seem to hold at all for clausal doubling. To begin with, it is far from obvious what kind of constituent *CLAUSE 1* is in order to move to the left periphery. As discussed, *CLAUSE 1* is always headed by the complementizer *que* ‘that’, so the most straightforward analytical option is assuming that *CLAUSE 1* is a CP. However, the hypothesis that *CLAUSE 1* is a displaced CP leads to a puzzling analysis for examples such as (14), in which *CLAUSE 2* is in the matrix domain.

- (14) Qué leyó el libro, leyó el libro.
 that read.3SG the book read.3SG the book
 ‘As for her reading the book, she DID read the book.’

¹As is known, only preverbal subjects trigger island effects in Spanish (e.g., Haegeman et al. 2014).

Under the standard assumption that dislocated elements occupy a position within the CP (i.e., Spec,CP), CLAUSE 1 should be a copy of an intermediate projection of the matrix CP, i.e., the smallest portion of the sentence that contains the complementizer, e.g., (15). Such a derivation introduces a number of theoretical concerns that make it plainly implausible: (i) it involves movement of a non-phrasal element C'; (ii) it requires an instance of movement that is not formulable within the *Agree* system (Chomsky 2000, 2001) as there is no attracting head in this configuration; and (iii) it trivially violates *anti-locality* (Abels 2003, Grohmann 2003).

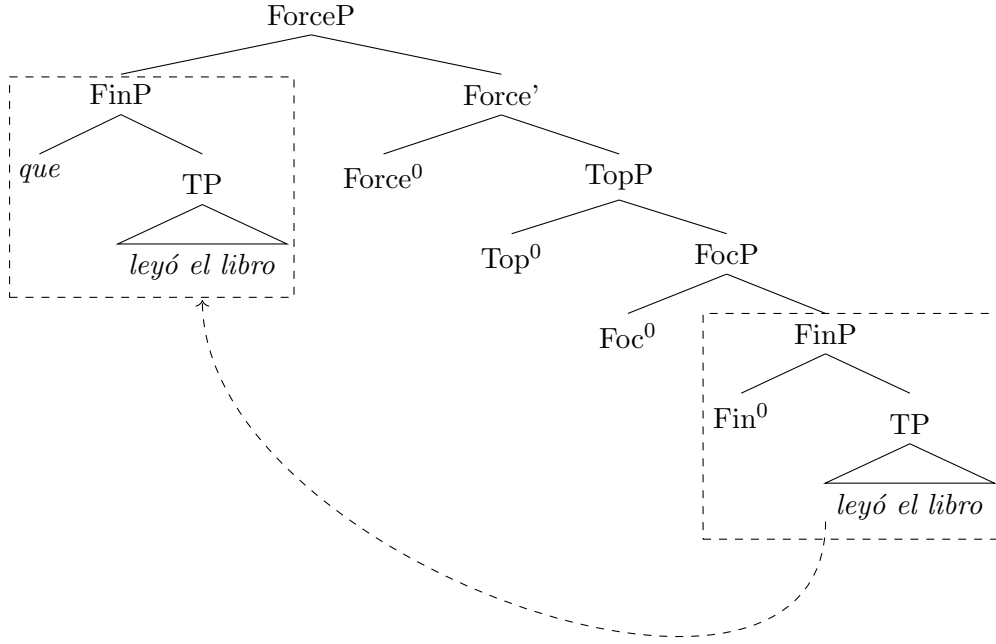


An alternative approach involves assuming that CLAUSE 1 is not truly a CP, but a left-peripheral projection headed by an element spelled-out as *que*. This idea goes in line with Demonte & Fernández-Soriano's (2009) proposal that Spanish has two types of *que*, each of them realizing distinct heads in the Rizian (1997) left-periphery: Force⁰ and Fin⁰.

(16) [_{ForceP} *que*₁ [_{TopP} ... [_{FocP} ... [_{FinP} *que*₂ [_{TP} ...

Following this scheme, one might propose that CLAUSE 1 is a copy of FinP occupying the Spec,CP position, e.g., (17). This approach shares none of the technical issues attested with (15) and still explains the unacceptability of the examples in (12) as island violations.

(17)



However, this analysis makes the wrong predictions about the internal syntax of CLAUSE 1. In particular, the dislocated clause can host topics within its structure, which are supposed to occupy positions above *FinP* in the left periphery of the sentence. This can be seen in (18), where both clauses display clitic left-dislocation. This shows that, if the scheme in (16) by Demonte & Fernández-Soriano is adopted, CLAUSE 1 must be taken to be an occurrence of *ForceP*, i.e., a complete CP projection.

- (18) Que el libro lo leyó, el libro lo leyó.
 that the book it read.3SG the book it read.3SG
 ‘As for her reading the book, she DID read it.’

In sum, CLAUSE 1 seems to behave as a full CP, but analyzing it as one introduces non-trivial problems for a movement-based account of clausal doubling. Perhaps there are other analytical alternatives that would make an approach in the lines of (13) work, but they would certainly deviate from standard assumptions. The point remains that positing that the duplicate clauses in the construction are copies is not as immediate as with verbs in predicate doubling.

A second type of argument against an analysis of clausal doubling in the lines of (13) comes from the observation that nominals within both clauses are not required to be identical. Following standard considerations within copy theory (Nunes 2004, 2011), if two elements are copies and belong to the same movement chain, they need to be isomorphic, i.e., they must have exactly the same syntactic structure and contain exactly the same constituents. This is not borne out for clausal doubling. Just as Saab (2017) originally noticed for the predicate doubling construction, the nominal phrases within CLAUSE 1 seem to behave as mere anaphoric antecedents for their correlates within CLAUSE 2. Thus, for instance, while the leftmost clause contains a full DP as a direct object in (19a), its counterpart within the matrix domain can be an accusative clitic. The same scenario arises with other traditional anaphoric elements such as strong pronouns (19b), epithets (19c), or null subjects (19a).

- (19) a. Que Eliana_i leyó el libro_j, *pro*_i lo_j leyó.
 that Eliana read.3SG the book it read.3SG
 ‘As for reading the book, she DID read it.’

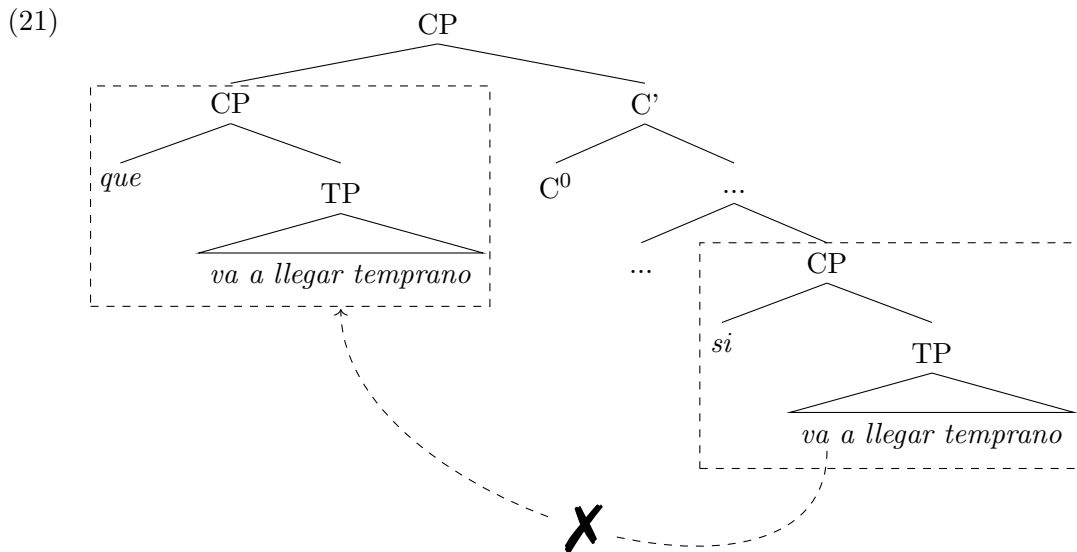
- b. Que *pro_i* habló con Juan_j, *pro_i* habló con él_j.
 that talked.3SG with Juan talked.3SG with he
 ‘As for talking to Juan, she DID talk to him.’
- c. Que *pro_i* habló con Juan_j, *pro_i* habló con ese idiota_j.
 that talked.3SG with Juan talked.3SG with that idiot
 ‘As for talking to Juan, she DID talk to that idiot.’

The lack of identity between these elements severely undermines the potential claim that CLAUSE 1 and CLAUSE 2 are syntactic copies generated through movement.

A further example showing the lack of identity between both clauses has already been presented in (11c), which we repeat for convenience in (20). As can be seen, the complementizers heading each clause are not required to be the same: while CLAUSE 1 must be headed by *que* ‘that’, CLAUSE 2 can be headed by *si* ‘whether’; in other words, the dislocated clause is always declarative, while its counterpart can be interrogative.

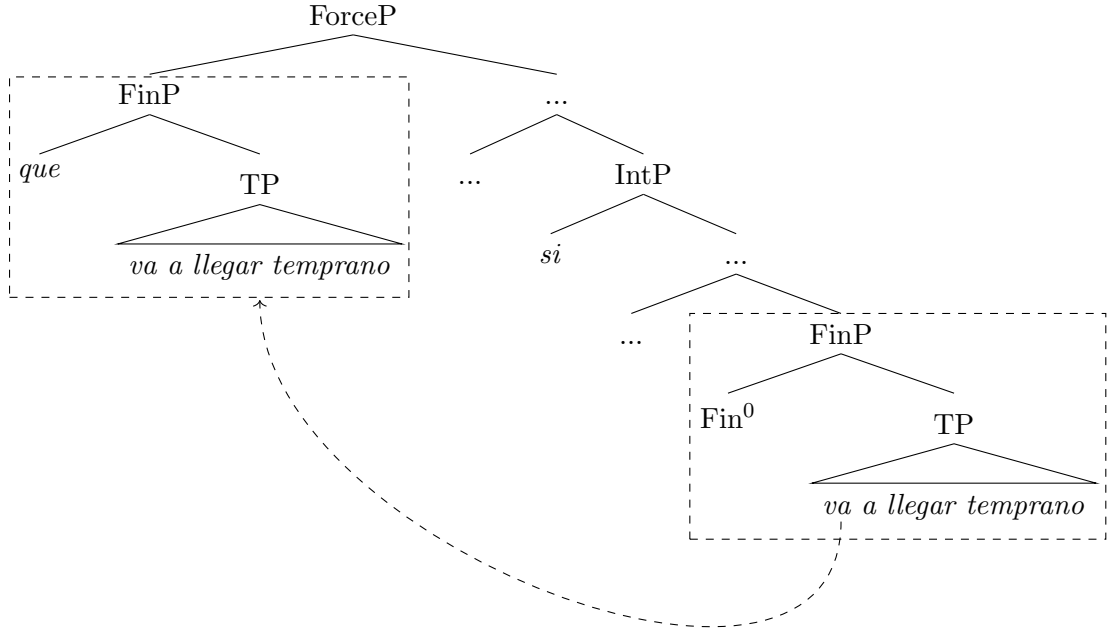
- (20) Que va a llegar temprano, no sé si va a llegar temprano.
 that go.3SG to arrive early, not know.1SG whether go.3SG to arrive early
 ‘As for her/him arriving early, I don’t know whether she/he will arrive early.’

This is problematic for the schematic analyses we sketched in (15) and (17). For the former, (20) demonstrates in a conclusive way that the clauses cannot be copies of the same CP.



As for the derivation in (17), a rich left periphery offers analytical options that are more difficult to rule out. For instance, one could assume that (20) is derived through movement of FinP; the head of this projection receives pronunciation as *que* ‘that’ when dislocated. The form *si* ‘whether’ could be the spell-out of an interrogative projection IntP in some position between ForceP and FinP (Rizzi 2001). The representation in (22) captures the idea.

(22)



Besides the problems already pointed out regarding (17), this new derivation introduces inconsistencies with respect to the patterns of complementizer pronunciation in Spanish. That is, if (i) Int^0 can be pronounced as *si* ‘whether’ (Rizzi 2001, Rizzi & Bocci 2017), and (ii) Fin^0 can be pronounced as *que* ‘that’ (Demonte & Fernández-Soriano 2009), the resulting structure prefigures the existence of patterns such as (23), in which *si* precedes *que*; notice that this ungrammatical sentence should be, in a sense, the base structure over which the movement in (22) applies. However, there seems to be no Spanish dialect combining *que* and *si* in this fashion.

- (23) *No sé si que va a llegar temprano.
 not know.1SG whether that go.3SG to arrive early
 ‘I don’t know whether it will rain.’

The unacceptability of (23) is problematic since the most straightforward evidence for *si* ‘whether’ and *que* ‘that’ being realizations of Int^0 and Fin^0 , respectively, comes from patterns in which both elements co-occur with other overt complementizers within the same left periphery. For the case of overt instances of Int^0 , there is the classic observation by Plann (1982) that *que* ‘that’ and *si* ‘whether’ can form the sequence *que si* ‘that whether’ in embedded (“reported”) questions, e.g., (24). As for Fin^0 , Demonte & Fernández-Soriano (2009) report patterns with two overt instances of *que* ‘that’ such as (25).

- (24) Me preguntó que si te visitaron en Granada.
 DAT.1SG asked.3SG that whether ACC.2SG visited.3PL in Granada
 ‘She asked me whether they visited you in Granada.’
- (25) Le gritó que qué mala cara que tenía.
 DAT.3SG shouted.3SG that what bad face that had.3SG
 ‘He shouted him how awful she looked.’

Since these patterns exist, the expectation that arises from the syntactic spine in (22) is that the sequence *si que* ‘whether that’ in (23) should be attested in some grammatical context in some Spanish dialect. As said, this is not the case.

There is also a more traditional overgeneration problem: if the derivation in (22) was on the right track, there should be analogous structures with no multiple copy pronunciation. That is,

since the example in (20) involves (a projection within) the complement of IntP moving to the left, then it should be possible to form Spanish sentences in which Int⁰ remains stranded at the very end of the sentence. As the unacceptability of (26) shows, this prediction is not borne out.

- (26) a. *Que va a llegar temprano, no se si.
 that go.3SG to arrive early, not know.1SG whether
 ‘As for her/him arriving early, I don’t know whether.’
 b. [FinP Que va a llegar temprano] no sé [IntP si [FinP ~~que va a llegar temprano~~]]

In sum, while theoretically plausible, the analysis in (22) requires a combination of complementizer-like heads whose overt realization together is unattested in Spanish. Moreover, the derivation in (22) wrongly predicts the grammaticality of a non-doubling version of (20).

So far, it seems that the only reason for pursuing a movement-based analysis of clausal doubling has to do with its (apparent) island sensitivity. As mentioned, the reasoning here goes more or less as follows: if a construction displays restrictions that are attested with movement dependencies, then it must be the case that its derivation involves movement. While we believe this line of reasoning is wrong, we also contend that clausal doubling does not really behave as real A’-dependencies do. That is, while clausal doubling displays constraints that (seemingly) overlap with restrictions attested in A’-movement, it also exhibits important differences suggesting that the phenomenon does not involve movement operations.

A first difference between clausal doubling and A’-movement in Spanish has to do with preposition stranding. As is known, Spanish is a language that does not license preposition stranding, at least in the most transparent scenarios. Thus, when forming a wh-question with the complement of a preposition like *en* ‘in’, the whole PP needs to move to the left periphery.

- (27) a. *¿Qué_i confías en ~~qué_i~~?
 what trust.2SG in what
 ‘What do you trust in?’
 b. ¿En qué_i confías ~~en~~ ~~qué_i~~?
 in what trust.2SG in what
 ‘In what do you trust?’

Fronting of full clauses works in exactly the same way: if a CP is complement of a PP, it cannot move to the left alone; it needs to carry with it its selecting preposition.

- (28) a. *Que vas a venir, confío en.
 that go.2SG to come trust.1SG in
 ‘That you will come, I trust in.’
 b. En que vas a venir, confío.
 in that go.2SG to come trust.1SG
 ‘In that you will come, I trust.’

Clausal doubling functions in a very different way. As can be seen in (29a), the doubling pattern is possible when CLAUSE 2 is within a PP. In this scenario, CLAUSE 1 cannot be headed by the prepositional head, e.g., (29a) vs. (29b).

- (29) a. Que vas a venir, confío en que vas a venir.
 that go.2SG to come trust.1SG in that go.2SG to come
 ‘As for you coming, I trust that you will come.’

- b. *En que vas a venir, confío en que vas a venir.
 in that go.2SG to come trust.1SG in that go.2SG to come

The contrast between (28) and (29) is difficult to explain under the hypothesis that CLAUSE 1 is generated through movement: why would preposition stranding be grammatical in (29a) but impossible in (28a)? Conversely, why would movement of the PP be ungrammatical in (29b) but legal in (28b)? This stark difference between clausal doubling and fronting of full clauses further suggests that the former does not involve multiple copy pronunciation.

Scenarios in which CLAUSE 2 functions as the complement of a preposition introduce a further explanatory puzzle. While clausal doubling is fully grammatical when CLAUSE 2 is within the prepositional complement of *confiar* ‘trust’, e.g., (29a), the same pattern becomes unacceptable with verbs such as *hablar* ‘talk’ or *conformar* ‘conform’.

- (30) a. *Que vas a venir, hablamos de que vas a venir.
 that go.2SG to come talk.1PL of that go.2SG to come
 ‘As for you coming, we talked about (the fact) that you are going to come.’
 b. *Que vas a venir, me conformo con que vas a venir.
 that go.2SG to come REFL.1SG conform.1SG with that go.2SG to come
 ‘As for you coming, I’m satisfied with (the fact) that you are going to come.’

This contrast does not follow from the hypothesis that CLAUSE 1 and CLAUSE 2 are copies. Instead, the pattern seems to be related to the meaning of the embedding verb. That is, while *confiar* ‘trust’ can be interpreted as expressing some form of evidentiality, e.g., by reporting a reasoned expectation of the truth of the embedded clause, this type of reading is not available with *hablar* ‘talk’ or *conformar* ‘conform’. An account of the contrast between (29a) and (30) exploiting this observation could be compatible with a movement-based analysis of clausal doubling, but it can also work with an analysis of the construction in which CLAUSE 1 is base-generated in the left periphery. We will defend the latter approach in section 4.

Another domain in which clausal doubling and A’-movement differ involves factive verbs such as *olvidarse* ‘forget’ or *lamentar* ‘regret’. This type of verb is known to trigger weak island effects: they are selective regarding the constituents that can be extracted from them (Szabolcsi & Lohndal 2017, i.a.). For instance, the CP complement of *olvidarse* ‘forget’ allows extraction of direct objects, e.g., (31a), but forbids extraction of manner adjuncts, e.g., (31a).

- (31) a. ¿Qué libro_i te olvidaste [CP que compraste ~~qué libro~~_i
 what book CL.2SG forget.2SG that bought.2SG what book
 impulsivamente]?
 impulsively
 ‘What book did you forget that you bought impulsively?’
 b. *¿Cómo_i te olvidaste [CP que compraste el libro ~~cómo~~_i]?
 how CL.2SG forgot.2SG that bought.2SG the book how
 ‘How did you forget that you bought the book?’

The fact that the embedded CP is an island itself does not imply that it cannot move. For example, the CP complement of verbs like *olvidarse* ‘forget’ or *lamentar* ‘regret’ can move to the left periphery when focus-fronted.

- (32) a. Que compré el LIBRO te olvidaste.
 that bought.1SG the book CL.2SG forgot.2SG
 ‘That I bought the BOOK you forgot.’

- b. Que LLUEVA lamento.
that rains.3SG regret.1SG
'That it RAINS I regret.'

Therefore, under the assumption that clausal doubling involves movement, the unacceptability of the sentences in (33) is mysterious.

- (33) a. *Que compré el libro, te olvidaste que compré el libro.
that bought.1SG the book CL.2SG forgot.2SG that bought.1SG the book
'As for me buying the book, you forgot that I bought the book.'
- b. *Que llueva, lamento que llueva.
that rains.3SG regret.1SG that rains.3SG
'As for it raining, I regret it rains.'

In particular, the ill-formation of these examples cannot be attributed to the island constraint attested in (31), as there is no extraction from within the complement of the factive verbs.

A final difference between clausal doubling and A'-movement is that the former is not sensitive to *all* island domains. In particular, the construction can obviate complex NP islands, i.e., CLAUSE 2 may appear within noun complements.²

- (34) a. Que compró el auto, escuché el rumor de que lo compró.
that bought.3SG the car heard.1SG the rumor of that it bought.3SG
'As for her buying the car, I heard the rumor that she/he DID buy it.'
- b. Que tomó vino, me llegó el comentario de que tomó.
that drank.3SG wine me got.3SG the comment of that drank.3SG
'As for her drinking wine, I got the comment that she DID drink it.'

True A'-extractions from complex NPs in Spanish lead to deviant results, e.g., (35).

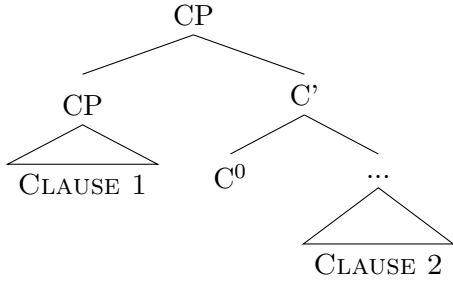
- (35) a. *¿Qué escuchaste el rumor de que compró?
what heard.2SG the rumor of that bought.3SG
'What did you hear the rumor that she bought?'
- b. *¿Qué te llegó el comentario de que tomó?
what you got.3SG the comment of that drank.3SG
'What did you get the comment that she drank?'

Thus, the acceptability of the examples in (34) is unexpected under the assumption that clausal doubling involves movement.

In sum, there is little to no reason to assume that CLAUSE 1 and CLAUSE 2 are copies generated through syntactic movement. Accordingly, we contend instead that there is no transformational relation between the clauses in the construction. That is, we take it that CLAUSE 1 is simply a base-generated CP in matrix Spec,CP.

(36)

²As we show in section 3, this is only possible when the matrix predicate can receive a *parenthetical interpretation*, that is, when it functions as a kind of evidential (Simons 2007).



Once a movement-based approach is ruled out, the natural question that arises is how to account for the island effects attested in (12). We propose that these restrictions can be explained by appealing to no syntactic locality constraint. In short, we argue that the unacceptability of the examples in (12) is a byproduct of the information structure of the clausal doubling construction.

3 Informational properties of clausal doubling

Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022) demonstrate that the apparent island effects in the Spanish predicate doubling construction follow from the dislocated predicate being a *contrastive topic*. Our core argument here parallels their proposal: we contend that the restrictions attested in (12) reduce to the fact that the dislocated clause of the clausal doubling construction also functions as a contrastive topic.

In what follows, we introduce the precise characterization of contrastive topics that we will assume throughout the rest of this paper, and then we will show that it applies to the part of the construction that we have called **CLAUSE 1**.

3.1 Contrastive topics

A contrastive topic introduces the reading that there are other topics, with their corresponding comments, that are relevant in context. Consider for instance the dialogue in (37), in which the NP *Fred* in the answer functions as a contrastive topic:

- (37) A: What did you people eat?
 B: Well, Fred ate the beans. (adapted from Büring 2003)

The reply in (37B) suggests that other people ate other stuff. Potential continuations to this utterance go in the lines of *Mary ate the eggplant*, *George ate the tuna*, *Elaine ate the carrots*, and so on. That is, (37B) implies an interpretation in which other topics, i.e., *Mary*, *George*, *Elaine*, etc., have their corresponding different comment, i.e., *ate the eggplant*, *ate the tuna*, *ate the carrots*, etc.

To capture this sort of interpretation, we follow the theory of contrastive topics in Büring (2003). According to him, whereas focus relates a declarative sentence to a set of alternative propositions, i.e., the *f-value* of the sentence in terms of Rooth (1992, 1996), a contrastive topic relates a sentence to a set of alternative questions, i.e., the *CT-value* of the sentence. The need to address these questions explains why further implicit topics are deemed relevant.

Following Büring (2003), we take it that the CT-value of a sentence obtains through a two-step process that we depict in simplified form in (38).³

³In a sense, this is our own implementation of the CT-Value formation algorithm in Büring (2003).

(i) CT-VALUE FORMATION (Büring 2003: 519)

- (38) Given a sentence S containing an element marked as a contrastive topic CT:
- Calculate the question Q such that $\llbracket Q \rrbracket \subseteq \llbracket S \rrbracket^f$.⁴
 - Replace the material in Q corresponding to the CT in S for salient alternatives.

To illustrate the functioning of (38), consider once again the reply in (37B), repeated with convenient markings in (39).

- (39) $[\text{Fred}]_{\text{CT}}$ ate $[\text{the beans}]_{\text{F}}$

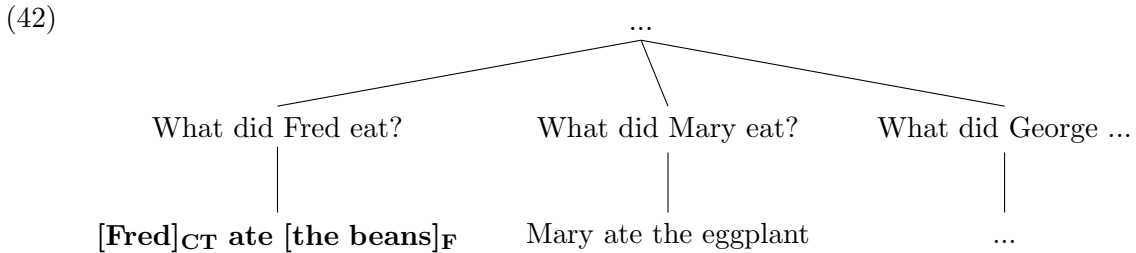
The subrule in (38a) aims to retrieve a question that is congruent with the sentence containing the contrastive topic. We follow the traditional definition of *congruence* as a subset relation between the denotation of the question and the f-value of the answer (Rooth 1992, 1996); alternatively, a definition based on equivalency (e.g., Roberts 1996, 2012) would grant similar results. Thus, for the case in (39), we need to retrieve the semantic object Q such that $\llbracket Q \rrbracket \subseteq \llbracket (39) \rrbracket^f$. Since the f-value of (39) is composed of propositions of the form *Fred ate x* , the question with a congruent set of potential answers is the one in (40).

- (40) What did Fred eat?

As for (38b), it is meant to inspect Q and replace within it the material corresponding to the contrastive topic in the original sentence. Since the constituent marked as a contrastive topic in (39) is the NP *Fred*, this noun must be replaced in (40) to obtain further questions. Assuming that (39) was uttered in a context in which the nouns *Mary*, *George* and *Elaine* are also relevant, these elements are potential replacements for *Fred*. Thus, the CT-value of (39) is the set of alternative questions depicted in (41).

- (41) $\llbracket (39) \rrbracket^{ct} = \{\text{What did Fred eat?}, \text{What did Mary eat?}, \text{What did George eat?}, \text{What did Elaine eat?}\}$

This result can be summarized in a D(iscourse)-tree (Büring 2003).



This representation shows that an utterance like (39) containing a contrastive topic: (i) completely addresses its *immediate question under discussion* iQUD (Roberts 1996, 2012), and (ii)

-
- Replace the focus with a wh-word and front the latter; if focus marks the finite verb or negation, front the finite verb instead.
 - Form a set of questions from the result of (a) by replacing the contrastive topic with some alternative to it.

As can be seen, this algorithm derives the CT-value by applying syntactic changes to a sentence. The problem with it is that it requires further modifications and assumptions in order to apply satisfactorily to doubling constructions; see Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022: 1174) for relevant discussion.

⁴Informally speaking, the set of propositions denoted by the question must be a subset of the focus value of the sentence.

evokes a set of alternative questions that altogether address a “bigger” question, e.g., *who ate what?* The need to answer these implicit questions generates the interpretation that further things need to be commented upon in order to resolve the more general issue under discussion. This is why contrastive topics introduce the reading that other pairs of topic and comment are relevant in context.

3.2 The information structure of clausal doubling

Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2023) observe that the clausal doubling construction triggers a “continuation effect” analogous to the one observed in the example in (37B), i.e., a sentence involving clausal doubling suggests that further topics need to be elaborated on to completely address the matter at hand. For comparison, consider first how a sentence without clausal doubling is interpreted in the context of a question.

- (43) A: ¿Leyó el libro Juan?
 read.3SG the book Juan
 ‘Did Juan read the book?’
 B: Lo leyó.
 it read.3SG
 ‘He read it.’

The answer in (43B) fully answers the question: it confirms that Juan did study, and settles the issue. On the contrary, a sentence with clausal doubling suggests (and even requires) a continuation contrasting with the proposition expressed by CLAUSE 1. Consider for instance the following dialogue:

- (44) A: ¿Leyó el libro Juan?
 read.3SG the book Juan
 ‘Did Juan read the book?’
 B: Que Juan leyó el libro, lo LEYÓ.
 that Juan read.3SG the book it read.3SG
 ‘As for Juan reading the book, he DID read it.’
 A: ¿Pero...?
 but
 ‘But...?’

The reply in (44B) not only constitutes a complete answer to the question *did Juan read the book?*, but also signals that something else needs to be said in order to fully solve the matter under discussion. Potential continuations go in the line of *but he didn’t like it*, *but he misunderstood the plot*, *but he never wrote the report*, and so on. In the absence of a follow-up like these, Speaker A’s most probable response would be to ask *but what?*

Following the analysis in Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2023), we take it that this “continuation effect” stems from CLAUSE 1 being a contrastive topic in Büring’s (2003) sense. That means that the dislocated material indicates the presence of an implicit super-question at play that includes not only the iQUD, but at least one alternative sister-question to it. If this is correct, we should be able to retrieve the relevant discourse structure of (44B) by applying the rules in (38), just as we did for example (39) above. To do so, we first need to identify the focal structure of the sentence.

Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2023) argue that clausal doubling triggers verum focus marking over the propositional content of the duplicated clauses, i.e., the construction emphasizes the positive

polarity of the proposition p expressed within both CLAUSE 1 and CLAUSE 2.^{5,6} Accordingly, the doubling pattern is felicitous only in contexts in which negation of the proposition p is salient, for example, scenarios in which someone asserts $\neg p$, e.g., (45A), or asks a polar question $?p$ with some bias towards $\neg p$, e.g., (45A’).

- (45) A: María no leyó el libro
 María not read.3SG the book
 ‘María did not read the book.’
 A’: ¿María realmente leyó el libro?
 María really read.3SG the book
 ‘Did María really read the book?’
 B: Que leyó el libro, lo LEYÓ.
 that read.3SG the book it read.3SG
 ‘As for reading the book, she DID read it.’

We take it that verum focus in the construction involves F-marking on a polarity head scoping over CLAUSE 2 (Goodhue 2018, 2022, Samko 2016). For concreteness, we assume that the relevant head is Σ^0 (Laka 1990).⁷ Under these assumptions, clausal doubling sentences exhibit the following information structure: on the one hand, CLAUSE 1 functions as a contrastive topic; on the other, CLAUSE 2 receives a verum focus interpretation due to F-marking of the head of the projection ΣP immediately dominating CLAUSE 2. In sum, the information structure we assume for a sentence like (44B) is depicted in (46).

- (46) [Que Juan leyó el libro]_{CT}, Σ_F lo leyó.
 that Juan read.3SG the book it read.3SG
 ‘As for Juan reading the book, he DID read it.’

We are now in a position to get the discourse structure for this example by applying the rules in (38). According to (38a), we need to retrieve the iQUD for (46), i.e., the question Q such that $\llbracket Q \rrbracket \subseteq \llbracket (46) \rrbracket^f$. Given that this sentence involves verum focus, its f -value comprises the propositions $p = \text{Juan read the book}$ and $\neg p = \text{Juan didn't read the book}$. The question with a congruent set of potential answers is the polar question $?p$ in (47).

⁵For an up-to-date discussion of the notion of *verum*, see Jordanoska et al. (2023)

⁶Clausal doubling does not license other forms of narrow focus marking, e.g., (i), and it is infelicitous in broad focus contexts, e.g., (ii). See Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2023) for a more detailed discussion of the distribution of focus in this construction.

- (i) a. *Que leyó, leyó EL LIBRO (no la revista).
 that read.3SG read.3SG the book not the magazine
 ‘As for reading, she/he read THE BOOK (not the magazine).’
 b. *Que estudié, estudié YO (no Pedro).
 that studied.1SG studied.1SG I not Pedro
 ‘As for studying, I studied (not Pedro).’
 (ii) A: ¿Qué pasó?
 what happened
 ‘What happened?’
 B: # Que estudié, estudié.
 that studied.1SG studied.1SG
 ‘As for me studying, I DID study.’

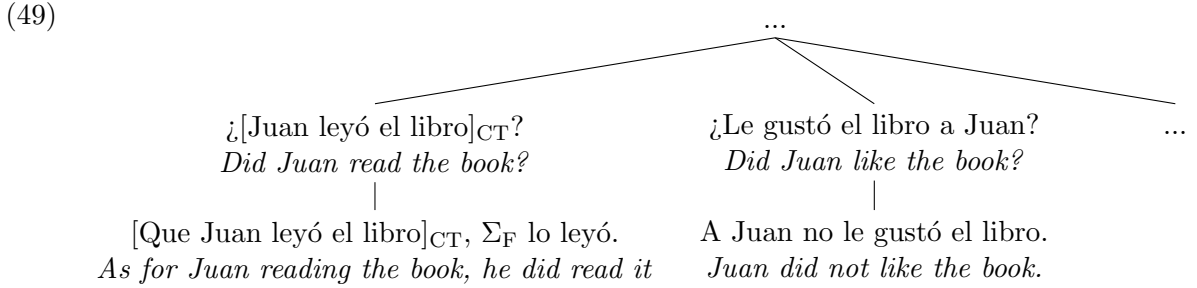
⁷Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2023) argue that clausal doubling involves focus on a polarity-like head occupying a high position within the left periphery, i.e., above ΣP . Such an assumption, however, would be superfluous for the discussion at hand.

(47) Did Juan read the book?

Following (38b), the next step is to retrieve a CT-value by replacing the information expressed by the contrastive topic within the iQUD in (47). Since the clausal doubling construction always has a contrastive topic expressing a full proposition p , replacing a parallel element within $?p$ would produce alternative polar questions, e.g., $?q$, $?r$, $?s$. For the case at hand, the example in (46) has a contrastive topic expressing the proposition $p = \text{Juan read the book}$. Replacing this information in (47) for the proposition $q = \text{Juan liked the book}$ generates the question $?q = \text{did Juan like the book?}$; replacement for other propositions would generate other questions. Thus, the CT-value for (46) is the set of polar questions depicted in (48).

(48) $\llbracket(46)\rrbracket^{ct} = \{\text{Did Juan read the book?}, \text{Did Juan like the book?}, \dots\}$

This treatment successfully accounts for the “continuation effect” described before: the doubling pattern evokes alternative question contrasting with the proposition expressed by CLAUSE 1, so that the potential follow-ups to (44B) mentioned above are just possible answers to these questions. This can be schematized in the following discourse tree.



This line of analysis allows to posit a powerful generalization about clausal doubling. By virtue of being a contrastive topic, CLAUSE 1 must always maintain a transparent relation with the iQUD of the sentence: if CLAUSE 1 expresses a proposition p , then the iQUD must be a question $?p$. This follows straightforwardly from the application of the rules in (38), which retrieves the iQUD from the f -value of the sentence, preserving the content of the contrastive topic.

Based on this generalization, we can derive a core condition of good formation for Spanish clausal doubling. Following Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022), we propose that the construction obeys a sentence-internal congruence condition between CLAUSE 1 and the rest of the utterance. In the formulation in (50), we call S the matrix sentence to which CLAUSE 1 attaches; put differently, S is a stand-in for the C' intermediate projection of the matrix domain in the scheme in (36).

(50) CONGRUENCE CONDITION FOR CLAUSAL DOUBLING

Given a clausal doubling sentence, if CLAUSE 1 expresses a proposition p , there must be a polar question Q of the form $?p$ such that $\llbracket Q \rrbracket \subseteq \llbracket S \rrbracket^f$.

In general terms, this condition captures the intuition that the dislocated contrastive topic must be relevant to the rest of its utterance. That is, CLAUSE 1 not only expresses a proposition p , but also presupposes that the non-dislocated material in the sentence (i.e., what we call S) serves as an answer for a polar question involving p . To illustrate, consider again the doubling sentence in (51).

(51) Que Juan leyó el libro, Σ_F lo leyó.
that Juan read.3SG the book it read.3SG
‘As for Juan reading the book, he DID read it.’

The condition in (50) requires the iQUD of this sentence to be a polar question built around the proposition introduced by CLAUSE 1. Given that the contrastive topic is *Juan read the book*, then the addressed question must be *Did Juan read the book?*. As for its denotation, we adopt a classic Hamblin’s semantics for polar questions, i.e., we assume that a polar question $?p$ denotes a set of two propositions, the positive and negative possible answers $\{p, \neg p\}$ (Hamblin 1973).

$$(52) \quad \llbracket Q \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{Did Juan read the book?} \rrbracket = \{ \text{Juan read the book}, \text{Juan did not read the book} \}$$

The second ingredient that is needed for congruence is the focus semantic value of S. As is standard, we assume that the f -value of a verum focus sentence is the set of alternatives $\{p, \neg p\}$, i.e., the proposition the sentence expresses and its negation (Goodhue 2022). Thus, the focus semantic value of the non-dislocated material in (51) is the set containing the propositions *Juan read the book* and *Juan did not read the book*.

$$(53) \quad \llbracket S \rrbracket^f = \llbracket \Sigma_F \text{ Juan read the book} \rrbracket^f = \{ \text{Juan read the book}, \text{Juan did not read the book} \}$$

As expected, the Congruence Condition in (50) is met: the denotation of the iQUD (52) is a subset of the f -value of the sentence (53). That means that the doubling pattern in (51) is correctly predicted to be well-formed.

$$(54) \quad \llbracket \text{Did Juan read the book?} \rrbracket \subseteq \llbracket \Sigma_F \text{ Juan read the book} \rrbracket^f$$

An informal way to validate this result is to construct a hypothetical dialogue in which a speaker felicitously answers the relevant iQUD by uttering the non-dislocated material in the original sentence. The following example illustrates the idea based on (51). As can be seen, the matrix clause is able to address a *yes/no* question about CLAUSE 1, i.e., the verum clause *lo leyó* ‘he did read it’ successfully answers a question about whether Juan read the book.⁸

- (55) A: ¿Juan leyó el libro?
 Juan read.3SG the book
 ‘Did Juan read the book?’
 B: Lo leyó.
 it read.3SG
 ‘He did read it.’

4 Clausal doubling produces phantom islands

Our main claim is that the clausal doubling constructions in (12) are deviant not due to restrictions on syntactic movement, but because they violate the congruence condition in (50), i.e., these are sentences that do not address the questions presupposed by their contrastive topics. In terms of Verdecchia (2023), these are *phantom islands*,⁹ that is, ill-formed structures that at first sight look like true island violations, but are just the result of some problem in the information structure of the sentence.

As a demonstration, consider again the example (12a), repeated below in (56). In this sentence, CLAUSE 2 occurs within a temporal adjunct.

⁸This does not mean that verum focus sentences are *always* felicitous in contexts of polar questions. As Gutzmann et al. (2020) point out, for verum marking to be licensed, the question must convey some bias towards the negative answer.

⁹This term can be seen as an extension of Ross’ (1967) original metaphor of islands as syntactic domains that block movement. In cartography, a *phantom island* is an island that was included on maps for an extended period of time, until it was eventually proven not to exist.

- (56) *Que leyó el libro, Juan se durmió después de que lo leyó.
 that read.3SG the book Juan SE slept.3SG after of that it read.3SG
 ‘As for him reading the book, Juan fell asleep after he DID read it.’

According to the congruence condition in (50), the iQUD of a clausal doubling sentence must be a polar question about the proposition expressed by the contrastive topic. Since in this example CLAUSE 1 introduces the proposition *Juan read the book*, the corresponding iQUD must be *did Juan read the book?*, which denotes the propositions $p = \text{Juan read the book}$ and $\neg p = \text{Juan did not read the book}$.

- (57) $\llbracket ?p \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{Did Juan read the book?} \rrbracket = \{ \text{Juan read the book}, \text{Juan did not read the book} \}$

As a second step to calculate congruence, we need to identify the f -value of S, i.e., of the non-dislocated material in the sentence. Under the assumption that clausal doubling triggers verum focus marking on CLAUSE 2 (cf. Section 3.2), the sentence in (56) denotes the following set of focal alternatives.

- (58) $\llbracket S \rrbracket^f = \llbracket \text{Juan fell asleep after he } \Sigma_F \text{ read the book} \rrbracket^f =$
 $\{ \text{Juan fell asleep after he read the book}, \text{Juan fell asleep after he did not read the book} \}$

The problem that arises for the sentence in (56) is that it does not comply with the congruence condition in (50): the denotation of the iQUD in (57) is not a subset of the f -value of S in (58).

- (59) $\llbracket \text{Did Juan read the book?} \rrbracket \not\subseteq \llbracket \text{Juan fell asleep after he } \Sigma_F \text{ read the book} \rrbracket^f$

The violation of the congruence condition reveals that (56) exhibits a mismatch between its contrastive topic and the rest of the sentence: the assertion in (56) is irrelevant to the question presupposed by CLAUSE 1. Informally speaking, the contrastive topic and the sentence it attaches to “talk about different things”. That is, while the contrastive topic is about an event of reading a book, the rest of the sentence is about an event of sleeping. As evidence for this claim, note that the non-dislocated material in (56) cannot function as a proper answer for the iQUD in (57) in a dialogue.

- (60) A: ¿Juan leyó el libro?
 Juan read.3SG the book
 ‘Did Juan read the book?’
 B: # Juan se durmió después de que lo leyó.
 Juan SE slept.3SG after of that it read.3SG
 ‘Juan fell asleep after he read it.’

This mismatch explains why the sentence in (56) is unacceptable without appealing to any syntactic locality constraint. The same account can be extended to other island domains in which clausal doubling produces deviant results. For completeness, we will discuss two further cases. Consider the example in (12b), repeated for convenience in (61). As can be seen, this doubling pattern involves a relative clause island.

- (61) *Que leyó el libro, vi a la mujer que lo LEYÓ.
 that read.3SG the book saw.1SG DOM the woman that it read.3SG
 ‘As for reading the book, I saw the woman who DID read it.’

The analysis of this example follows exactly the same reasoning as before. First, we need to obtain the iQUD from the proposition expressed by CLAUSE 1; since CLAUSE 1 expresses the proposition $p = \text{the woman read the book}$, its corresponding polar question $?p$ is *did the woman read the book?* in (62). Then, we need to calculate the focus semantic value of S; under the assumption that CLAUSE 2 expresses verum focus, the f -value of the sentence is the pair of propositions depicted in (63).

$$(62) \quad \llbracket ?p \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{Did the woman read the book?} \rrbracket = \\ \{ \text{the woman read the book, the woman did not read the book} \}$$

$$(63) \quad \llbracket S \rrbracket^f = \llbracket \text{I saw the woman that } \Sigma_F \text{ read the book} \rrbracket^f = \\ \{ \text{I saw the woman that read the book, I saw the woman that did not read the book} \}$$

Once again, the sentence fails at complying with the congruence requirement. That is, the set of propositions denoted by the question in (62) is not a subset of the f -value of S in (63).

$$(64) \quad \llbracket \text{Did the woman read the book?} \rrbracket \not\subseteq \llbracket \text{I saw the woman that } \Sigma_F \text{ read the book} \rrbracket^f$$

This result can be corroborated by the fact that the non-dislocated material in (61) cannot function as a felicitous answer for the proposed question.

- (65) A: ¿La mujer leyó el libro?
 the woman read.3SG the book
 ‘Did the woman read the book?’
 B: # Vi a la mujer que lo leyó.
 saw.1SG DOM the woman that it read.3SG
 ‘I saw the woman who read it.’

Finally, let’s consider the case of subject islands. Take the sentence in (12c), repeated below in (66). In this example, clausal doubling is unacceptable as CLAUSE 2 is located within a preverbal subject.

- (66) * Que leyó el libro, que hayas dicho que lo leyó me sorprendió.
 that read.3SG the book that had.2SG said that it read.3SG me surprised.3SG
 ‘As for her reading the book, that you had said that she DID read it surprised me.’

As in the previous cases, we need to calculate the question presupposed by CLAUSE 1 and the focus semantic value of the non-dislocated material in the sentence. These are sketched in (67) and (68), respectively.

$$(67) \quad \llbracket ?p \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{Did she read the book?} \rrbracket = \{ \text{she read the book, she did not read the book} \}$$

$$(68) \quad \llbracket S \rrbracket^f = \llbracket \text{that you had said that she } \Sigma_F \text{ read the book surprised me} \rrbracket^f = \\ \{ \text{that you had said that she read the book surprised me, that you had said that she did not read the book surprised me.} \}$$

As expected, the congruence condition in (50) is not met: the denotation of the question in (67) is not a subset of the f -value in (68).

$$(69) \quad \llbracket \text{Did the woman read the book?} \rrbracket \not\subseteq \llbracket \text{that you had said that she } \Sigma_F \text{ read the book surprised me} \rrbracket^f$$

Once again, the resulting analysis is corroborated by the fact that the non-dislocated material in this sentence fails at addressing the question presupposed by its contrastive topic.

- (70) A: ¿Leyó el libro?
 read.3SG the book
 ‘Did she read the book?’
 B: # Que hayas dicho que lo leyó me sorprendió.
 that had.2SG said that it read.3SG me surprised.3SG
 ‘That you had said that she DID read it surprised me.’

At this point, it is quite apparent that the mismatches preventing congruence to be satisfied in (59), (64) and (69) have to do with the embedding contexts being included in the computation of the f -value of each sentence, while not forming part of the corresponding iQUD. That is, the reason why $\llbracket Q \rrbracket$ is not a subset of $\llbracket S \rrbracket^f$ in any of these examples is because only the later incorporates the expressions to which CLAUSE 2 is subordinated, making disjoint the resulting sets of propositions. Following this logic, one might believe that any clausal doubling sentence in which CLAUSE 2 is an embedded clause would cause a congruence failure. This sloppy prediction is not borne out. As seen in examples like (11a), repeated below in (71), clausal doubling is acceptable if CLAUSE 2 functions as a completive clause.

- (71) Que trabajó, supongo que trabajó.
 that worked.3SG guess.1SG that worked.3SG
 ‘As for her/him working, I guess that she/he DID work.’

This behavior receives a very straightforward explanation. In typical cases, the *main point* of an utterance, i.e., the portion of the sentence expressing the asserted proposition, corresponds to the matrix domain. However, certain embedding predicates can receive so-called *parenthetical readings* (Urmson 1952, Hooper & Thompson 1973, Simons 2007). In these cases, the asserted content of the utterance is expressed in an embedded clause. As an example, consider the dialogue in (72).

- (72) A: Who was Louise with last night?
 B: I heard that she was with Bill.

As can be seen, the part of the utterance in (72B) answering to the question is contained in the embedded clause, while the main predicate is used parenthetically. Parenthetical predicates like these express illocutionary values and function as evidentials of sorts (Simons 2007). That is, they merely signal the source and reliability of the information contained in the embedded clause, but they are not part of the proposition being asserted.

- (73) I heard that she was with Bill. cf. (72B)
parenthetical *main point*

This is exactly what is at play in clausal doubling constructions when CLAUSE 2 functions as a completive clause: the matrix predicate receives a parenthetical reading, and therefore is excluded from the main point of the utterance. Since the embedded clause is the main point in these cases, it should be the only part of the utterance to be considered for the purposes of congruence. Thus, the embedding context must be ignored in these cases for the calculation of the f -value of the sentence.

Under these assumptions, let’s proceed with the calculation of congruence for (71). As always, the first step is to calculate the iQUD presupposed by CLAUSE 1. Since CLAUSE 1 expresses

the proposition $p = \textit{she/he worked}$, its corresponding polar question $?p$ is *did she/he work?* in (74).

$$(74) \quad \llbracket ?p \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{Did she/he work?} \rrbracket = \{ \textit{she/he worked}, \textit{she/he did not work} \}$$

Then, we need to calculate the focus semantic value of S; under the assumption that CLAUSE 2 that *verum focus* is expressed within CLAUSE 2, the f -value of the sentence is the pair of propositions depicted in (75). As can be seen, the resulting propositions incorporate only the information that is part of the main point of the utterance; the parenthetical portion is depicted in parenthesis and ignored in the computation of alternatives.

$$(75) \quad \llbracket S \rrbracket^f = \llbracket (\text{I guess that}) \textit{she/he } \Sigma_F \textit{worked} \rrbracket^f = \{ \textit{she/he worked}, \textit{she/he did not work} \}$$

Since the question $?p$ in (74) is a subset of the f -value in (75), the clausal doubling construction in (71) is successfully predicted to be well-formed. The fact that the non-dislocated material in (71) properly answers the iQUD introduced by CLAUSE 1 further corroborates this result, e.g., (76); notice that the felicitousness of this dialogue contrasts starkly with those depicted in (60), (65) and (70).

- (76) A: ¿Trabajó?
 worked.3SG
 ‘Did she/he work?’
 B: Supongo que trabajó.
 guess.1SG that worked.3SG
 ‘I guess that she/he DID work.’

The fact that parenthetical predicates are obviated from the computation of alternatives allows for a straightforward treatment of the behavior of clausal doubling in contexts of complex NP islands. As noticed regarding examples such as (34a), repeated for convenience in (77), clausal doubling seems insensitive to these island domains, i.e., the construction is acceptable if CLAUSE 2 functions as the complement of N.

- (77) Que compró el auto, escuché el rumor de que lo compró.
 that bought.3SG the car heard.1SG the rumor of that it bought.3SG
 ‘As for buying the car, I heard the rumor that she DID buy it.’

As proposed originally by Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022), we maintain that the embedding contexts of complex NP islands can, in some cases, be used parenthetically to indicate the origin or reliability of the information being conveyed. In these scenarios, the proposition expressed as the complement of the relevant NP becomes the main point the utterance, in exclusion of its embedding context. The prediction for clausal doubling is that CLAUSE 2 can occupy this position, as the congruence condition would be satisfied.

To illustrate, consider the analysis of (77). Since CLAUSE 1 expresses the proposition $p = \textit{she bought the car}$, the corresponding question $?p$ is *did she buy the car*, e.g., (78). Then, under the assumption that *verum focus* is expressed within CLAUSE 2, the focus semantic value of the sentence is as in (79); notice that the expression *I heard the rumour that* is not considered for the computation of alternatives as it receives a parenthetical interpretation.

$$(78) \quad \llbracket ?p \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{Did she buy the car?} \rrbracket = \{ \textit{she bought the car}, \textit{she did not buy the car} \}$$

$$(79) \quad \llbracket S \rrbracket^f = \llbracket (\text{I heard the rumour that}) \Sigma_F \textit{she bought the car} \rrbracket^f = \{ \textit{she bought the car}, \textit{she did not buy the car} \}$$

Since the resulting sets are equivalent, the congruence condition is satisfied.

$$(80) \quad \llbracket \text{Did she buy the car?} \rrbracket \subseteq \llbracket (\text{I heard the rumour that}) \Sigma_F \text{ she bought the car} \rrbracket^f$$

The dialogue in (81) supports this analysis. As can be seen, the question *¿compró el auto Juan?* ‘did Juan buy the car?’ can be felicitously answered with the non-dislocated material of the sentence in (77).

- (81) A: *¿Compró el auto Juan?*
 bought.3SG the car Juan
 ‘Did Juan buy the car?’
 B: *Escuché el rumor de que lo compró.*
 heard.1SG the rumor of that it bought.3SG
 ‘I heard the rumor that he bought it.’

Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022) observe that this is not always the case: certain predicates introducing complex nominals resist receiving parenthetical interpretations and require being part of the main point of the utterance. Thus, while *escuchar el rumor de* ‘to hear the rumour’ can be used parenthetically, expressions such as *apoyar la propuesta de* ‘to support the proposal’ cannot. This is illustrated in the dialogue in (82), in which a question like *¿qué compró Juan?* ‘what did Juan buy?’ cannot be answered by a sentence in which the main point is expressed as the complement of a noun.

- (82) A: *¿Qué compró Juan?*
 what bought.3SG Juan
 ‘What did Juan buy?’
 B: # *Cosmo apoyó la propuesta de que haya comprado un auto.*
 Cosmo supported.3SG the proposal of that had.3SG bought a car
 ‘Cosmo supported the proposal that he bought a car.’

Accordingly, clausal doubling produces deviant results if *CLAUSE 2* is embedded under an expression that cannot be interpreted parenthetically. For instance, if *CLAUSE 2* forms a complex nominal functioning as the complement of *apoyar* ‘support’, the resulting pattern is unacceptable.

- (83) * *Que comprara el auto, Cosmo apoyó la propuesta de que lo haya*
 that buy.3SG the car Cosmo supported.3SG the proposal of that it had.3SG
 comprado.
 bought
 ‘As for buying the car, Cosmo supported the proposal that he bought it.’

This outcome is trivially predicted under our analysis. Here, *CLAUSE 1* presupposes the question *did he buy the car*, e.g., (84). Then, since the embedding domain of *CLAUSE 2* rejects parenthetical readings, the focus semantic value of the sentence is a set of propositions containing the expression *Cosmo supported the proposal*, e.g., (85).

- (84) $\llbracket ?p \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{Did he buy the car?} \rrbracket^f = \{he \text{ bought the car, } he \text{ didn't buy the car}\}$
 (85) $\llbracket \text{Cosmo supported the proposal that } \Sigma_F \text{ he bought the car} \rrbracket^f =$
 $\{\text{Cosmo supported the proposal that he bought the car, Cosmo supported the proposal that}$
 $\text{he did not buy the car}\}$

Since these sets are disjoint, the congruence condition is not satisfied, which captures the unacceptability of (83).

- (86) $\llbracket \text{Did he buy the car?} \rrbracket \not\subseteq \llbracket \text{Cosmo supported the proposal that } \Sigma_F \text{ he bought the car} \rrbracket^f$

As a final case study, we analyze the behavior of the clausal doubling construction when CLAUSE 2 functions as the complement of a factive verb. Traditionally, these domains are known to display weak island effects: they are selective regarding the type of constituents that can be extracted from them, e.g., (31). As discussed in section 2, the peculiarity introduced by clausal doubling in these contexts is that the patterns do not seem to involve extraction, but they are unacceptable nevertheless. This can be seen in (33a), repeated below in (87).

- (87) *Que compré el libro, te olvidaste que compré el libro.
 that bought.1SG the book CL.2SG forgot.2SG that bought.1SG the book
 ‘As for me buying the book, you forgot that I bought the book.’

Our account captures this effect in the same terms as the previous patterns. On one hand, the question $?p$ presupposed by CLAUSE 1 is *did I buy the book?*, e.g., (88). Then, following the discussion in Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022), we take it that the embedding context of factive verbs cannot be interpreted parenthetically.¹⁰ Accordingly, the focus semantic value of the sentence is as depicted in (89).

- (88) $\llbracket ?p \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{Did I buy the book?} \rrbracket = \{I \text{ bought the book}, I \text{ didn't buy the book}\}$
 (89) $\llbracket S \rrbracket = \llbracket \text{You forgot that } \Sigma_F \text{ I bought the book} \rrbracket^f = \{\text{You forgot that I bought the book}, \text{you forgot that I didn't buy the book}\}$

As can be seen, these sets do not satisfy the congruence condition in (50), which captures the unacceptability of (87).

- (90) $\llbracket \text{Did I buy the book?} \rrbracket \not\subseteq \llbracket \text{You forgot that } \Sigma_F \text{ I bought the book} \rrbracket^f$

This result is corroborated by the infelicitousness of the corresponding dialogue.

- (91) A: ¿Compraste el libro?
 bought.2SG the book
 ‘Did you buy the book?’
 B: # Te olvidaste que lo compré.
 CL.2SG forgot.2SG that it bought.1SG
 ‘You forgot that I did buy it.’

The conclusion that arises from our analysis is that the selectivity of the island-like effects attested in clausal doubling depends entirely on whether the embedding context of CLAUSE 2 has a parenthetical interpretation or not. If it does, then the asserted content of the utterance reduces to CLAUSE 2, which allows to satisfy the congruence condition. On the other hand, if the embedding domain of CLAUSE 2 is part of the assertion, the congruence condition is deemed to be violated.

As anticipated, our account for why adjuncts, relative clauses and preverbal subjects prevent clausal doubling does not appeal to (narrow) syntactic constraints on movement. The discussion, however, does seem to point towards a correlation between syntactic and informational

¹⁰This contrasts starkly with the behavior of cognitive factives verbs, which allow parenthetical readings. See Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022) for discussion.

primitives: some structural domains traditionally known to forbid extraction are subordinated to expressions that cannot be interpreted parenthetically. A tempting hypothesis is to reduce this correlation to a single set of primitives by suggesting, for instance, that islands are opaque for extraction because they encode presupposed, i.e., non-asserted, information (Goldberg 2006, Ambridge & Goldberg 2008, Cuneo & Goldberg 2023). We explicitly reject this unifying point of view, as the behavior of complex NPs in clausal doubling constructions demonstrates that some island domains may contain asserted information. In slightly different terms, this type of approach faces the challenge of explaining why complex NPs prevent wh-extraction, e.g., (35), while still licensing clausal doubling, e.g., (77).

We take a more conservative approach. We follow Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022) in assuming that the propositional content of adjuncts, relative clauses and preverbal subjects is systematically *not-at-issue*,¹¹ while complex NP islands exhibit a more variable behavior based on lexical properties; notice that these are descriptive statements about specific syntactic configurations, not theoretical claims about islands in general. Moreover, we take it that the informational properties of these domains are concomitant with their (narrow) syntactic islandhood. That is, we conjecture that the nature of islands comprises a series of factors of different nature (syntactic, phonological, informational) conspiring to block long distance dependencies. Thus, for instance, phenomenology expected to fall under the label “complex NP island” has been shown here to rely, at least partially, on informational factors; the contrast between (77) and (83) was accounted for in these terms. Nevertheless, other complex NP patterns seemingly call for an explanation in (narrow) syntactic terms; this is the case of (35), whose ungrammaticality seems to be linked to structural properties.

At a more general level, the account of clausal doubling defended here introduces a methodological corollary. Islandhood is often taken as a reliable diagnosis for syntactic movement, i.e., if a dependency between two objects α and β is disrupted by an island domain, this usually leads to the conclusion that there is a movement-based relation between α and β . If the analysis presented throughout this section is on the right track, clausal doubling provides straightforward evidence against this line of thinking. In particular, the observable effects of movement in island domains could be the result of phantom islands.

5 Concluding remarks

In this paper, we analyzed the purported island-sensitivity of clausal doubling in Spanish, i.e., the fact that this doubling pattern cannot occur across island boundaries. To begin with, we demonstrated that both clauses appearing in this construction are independently generated and not syntactic copies, challenging the traditional view that island restrictions necessarily indicate syntactic movement. Instead, we argue that the island-like constraints observed with clausal doubling constitute cases of phantom islands—illusory “island effects” that arise as a byproduct of a mismatch in the information structure of the sentence. Building on Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia (2022, 2023), we first showed that the dislocated clause functions as a contrastive topic in Büring’s (2003) sense. Under this assumption, we proposed that, in the general case, doubling a clause appearing within an island domain leads to a violation of a congruence condition: in such scenarios, the sentence does not address the question presupposed by its contrastive topic. We argued that this analysis further accounts for the distribution of clausal doubling in embedding contexts, including clauses introduced by factive predicates or nouns.

From a broader perspective, clausal doubling in Spanish provides further evidence that certain

¹¹We take a proposition to be at-issue if it is intended to address the current question under discussion (Simons et al. 2010).

apparent “island effects” emerge from discourse-related constraints rather than syntactic principles, extending the analysis proposed by Muñoz Pérez & Verdecchia’s (2022) for predicate doubling. If on the right track, our approach also shows that islandhood cannot be considered an infallible diagnosis for movement: in some cases, information structure can create phantom islands.

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